

Chapter 114-1

In little Ling Dang's young heart, the old mansion had already become a frightening place.

Ling Dang didn't want to go back to the old mansion, didn't want to see her new auntie, and didn't want to see Grandpa and Grandma either.

She was afraid of being scolded, and also afraid of...

"Auntie, did Mommy go back too?" Ling Dang asked.

Liang Shi shook her head. "I'm not sure. Uncle only asked me to pick you up and bring you back to the old mansion. We're going to seek justice for Ling Dang today."

Liang Shi held Ling Dang's hand with one hand and Rainbow's with the other.

Her voice was gentle. Facing Ling Dang's fear, she softly comforted her. Ling Dang lowered her head and thought for a moment, then asked cautiously, "Will Uncle get scolded because of me?"

Liang Shi was stunned. "Huh?"

"I don't want Uncle to get scolded." Ling Dang shook her head. "Let's just forget about it."

It was hard to believe these words came from the mouth of a five-year-old girl.

Yet Ling Dang's words were sincere and her expression earnest—she was genuinely worried about Liang Xinzhou.

"And Mommy too." Ling Dang scratched at Liang Shi's palm. "Auntie, if we don't go back to the old mansion, we won't get scolded, right... When Grandma scolds Mommy, Mommy cries."

Liang Shi stood there in a daze for a few seconds, then said, "Then you can stay in the car and play with Rainbow. Auntie will go check on things at the old mansion, okay? If everyone's there, Grandma won't be so fierce."

Ling Dang looked a bit troubled, but in the end, she nodded.

Because they were going back to the old mansion, Ling Dang frowned and wore a dejected little face the whole way there.

Liang Shi teased her on the way, trying to cheer her up—nothing was going to happen to anyone.

Besides, they were just going back to discuss what happened that day and give Ling Dang the truth, not to start a big fight.

Most importantly, with Liang Xinzhou there, Liang Shi felt like she had someone to rely on.

Liang Xinzhou and Liang Xinhe had played the "pulling the rug out from under" card extremely well. Yesterday, Liang Wanwan had mentioned that without the two main pillars, Dongheng Group was so busy that no one's feet touched the ground. Especially Father Liang, who hadn't come home for several days—when Liang Wanwan went back that day, she didn't even see him.

And Qiu Zimin, troubled by her two sons' actions, was so depressed that she lay listlessly in bed without any sign of vitality.

Liang Shi's purpose in coming today was to get an explanation for what happened to Ling Dang that day. She had already witnessed the character of that family.

Bringing Ling Dang along was just to see how Qiu Zimin would handle things.

Since Ling Dang didn't want to go in, there was no need to force her.

It wasn't a big deal.

Liang Shi drove to the old mansion's entrance and reminded Rainbow and Ling Dang not to argue. The two of them could read books in the car or use the spare tablet to watch cartoons. If there was really a need, Liang Shi would come get them.

Rainbow nodded obediently.

Ling Dang asked worriedly, "Auntie, will you all really be okay?"

Liang Shi answered with certainty, "We'll be fine."

A moment later, she hesitated again. "If... if you all get scolded, let's just leave. I don't mind."

A touching light flickered in her small eyes.

Liang Shi patted her head. "I know. We're all adults, nothing will happen."

"But last time... Grandma hit Uncle." Ling Dang said somewhat dejectedly.

"Really, it's fine," Liang Shi said. "Last time your uncle wasn't prepared. That kind of situation won't happen again."

Ling Dang clearly didn't quite believe her.

Although she was still a child, she already knew who in the family was more powerful and who held the right to speak.

Before going in, Liang Shi told Ling Dang that if she wanted to go home, she could come inside. It didn't matter.

Ling Dang nodded in agreement.

There was a flower garden in front of the old mansion's courtyard. It was late autumn, a season when flowers should be withering, but the flowers in this garden were blooming in brilliant purples and reds.

The reason was that Qiu Zimin liked admiring flowers and enjoyed the feeling of vibrant spring.

So the flowers in the Liang family's garden were always flown in from all over the country and then planted in the garden.

As Liang Shi passed by the flower garden, petals were blown by the autumn wind and landed directly on her. She lowered her eyes and brushed them off with her hand.

Without sending Liang Xinzhou a message to confirm again, she went straight into the old mansion.

If there were any special circumstances, Liang Xinzhou would definitely notify her.

When she entered the old mansion, the servants all looked at her with disbelieving eyes, as if surprised that she would come back.

Because her previous image had been so bad, the servants greeted her with trepidation. "Third Miss."

This "Third Miss" was called out without much confidence, after all, there was already a new Third Miss in this household.

Liang Shi responded perfunctorily in a low voice, then walked over to Liang Xinzhou's side.

Liang Xinzhou and Liang Xinhe were both standing in the living room. Sun Meirou and Yu Wan were nowhere to be seen, having gone somewhere unknown.

Qiu Zimin sat on the sofa, her face full of sickly pallor, her posture listless. Her eyes were lightly closed, making her look like a seriously ill patient.

After Liang Shi came in, not knowing what the situation was, she didn't dare speak rashly.

But soon, Qiu Zimin slowly opened her eyes. Upon seeing her, intense hatred burst forth in her eyes. She said through gritted teeth, "What are you doing back here?"

"Just having a look around," Liang Shi said calmly.

The calmer she was, the angrier Qiu Zimin became. Soon, her expression changed. "Get out."

"I'll leave soon," Liang Shi said. "As long as you apologize to Ling Dang, I definitely won't stay here any longer."

"Who do you think you are?!" Qiu Zimin said angrily. "Ling Dang is my granddaughter! What standing do you have to say such things? Liang Shi, get out. I never want to see you again in my life!"

While cursing, she grabbed a throw pillow from beside her and threw it directly at Liang Shi.

It landed right in Liang Shi's arms.

Liang Shi's expression didn't change. Looking indifferent, she placed the pillow on the sofa on the other side. "I don't really want to see you either."

Things had already come to this point; there was no need to keep up pretenses.

Besides, Liang Shi had never intended to pretend with her from the beginning.

Qiu Zimin's health was indeed much worse than before. Troubles had come one after another recently. She had thought finding her biological daughter was wonderful news, and she was so happy she couldn't sleep the whole night. But then Liang Xinzhou desperately opposed it, showing no good attitude from the start, and her second son had directly moved out.

Fine, they had all established their own families and careers, so let them move out.

But then neither of them would even go to the company anymore.

Footnotes:

^{^1} "Pulling the rug out from under" (釜底抽薪, fǔ dǐ chōu xīn): A Chinese idiom meaning to remove the firewood from under the cauldron—a strategy to solve a problem by tackling its root cause. Here it refers to how the two brothers strategically withdrew their support from the family business to put pressure on their parents.